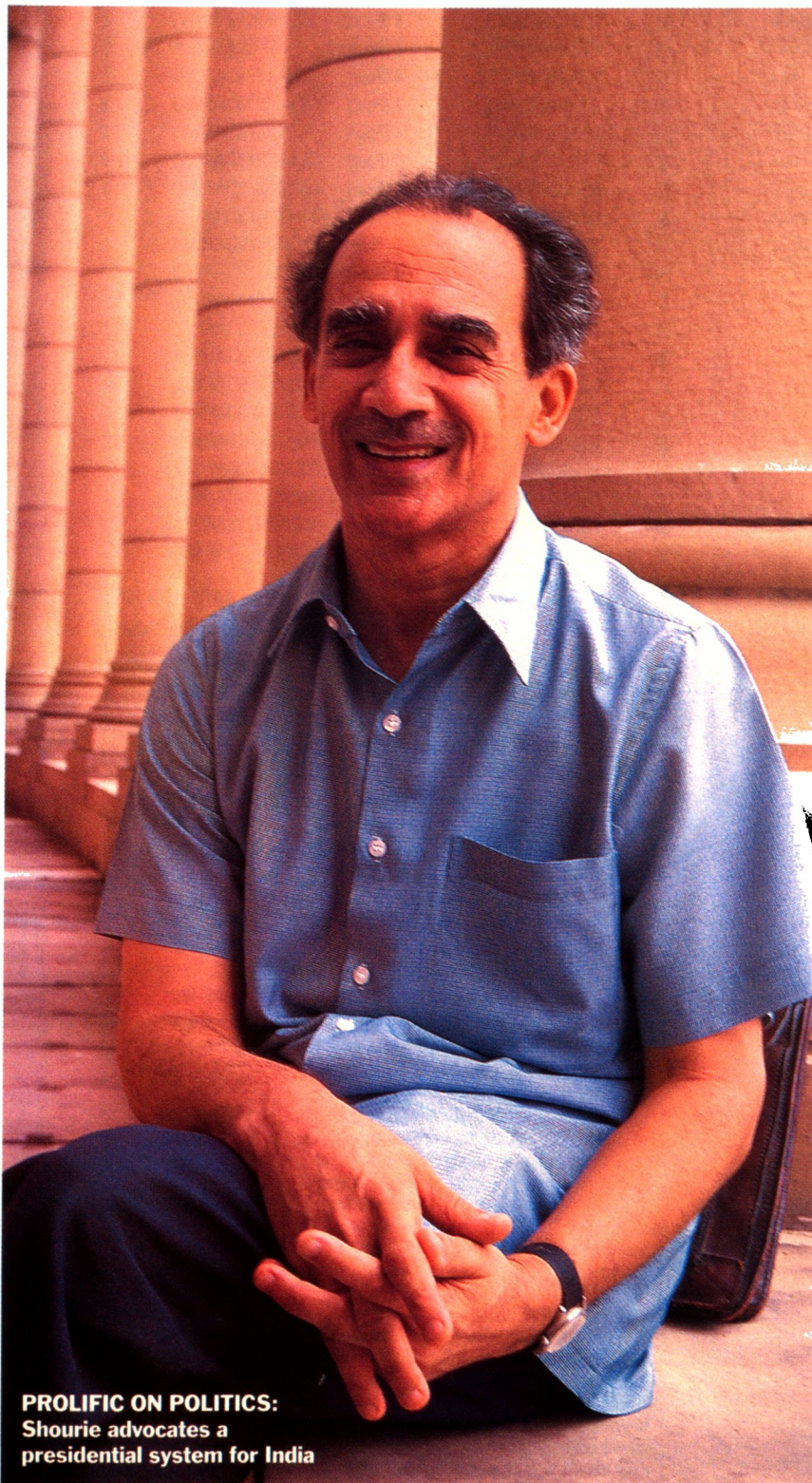


THE FAULT LINES OF POWER

In a scathing account of the egregious flaws plaguing the Indian parliamentary system, Shourie slams the legislature and talks of political reforms that are easier suggested than done



PROLIFIC ON POLITICS:
Shourie advocates a
presidential system for India

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA



THE PARLIAMENTARY SYSTEM

by ARUN SHOURIE

Rupa

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■ By Inder Malhotra

During a week when Parliament's proceedings were disrupted day after day before the session's abrupt end, what could have been more appropriate than reading Arun Shourie's latest book? The title may be simple, but the content is characteristically scathing about the mind-boggling degeneration of the Westminster system that we borrowed from Britain. This should be no surprise to those familiar with his sledgehammer style, whether as a crusading journalist or as a minister in Atal Bihari Vajpayee's government.

Much of what he has to say is well known. For instance, during the debate on Parliament versus the judiciary, many have underscored the absurdity of the politicians' claim that since they represent the "will of the people", Parliament must be "supreme". But thanks to the first-past-the-post system on the one hand, and the unending fragmentation of Indian polity on the other, most of our MPs and MLAs get through only by a minority of the votes polled. Shourie has cited chapter and verse to show that "99 per cent of members of legislatures have got in with a minority vote, 60 per cent of them with a minority of less than 30 per cent". And then he adds a stunning quotation from the Constitution Review Commission's report: "In some cases those who would otherwise have forfeited their security deposits have been declared elected as they obtained the highest number of votes amongst the candidates."

Added to this is the entry of criminals into Parliament. All political parties, while in the opposition, denounce this trenchantly but, when in power, defend it with the dubious argument that everyone must be presumed to be